

Computational Thinking

Discrete Mathematics

Number Theory

Topic 02 : Logic

Logic

Lecture 01 : Introduction to Propositional Logic

Dr Kieran Murphy 

Computing and Mathematics, SETU (Waterford).
(kieran.murphy@setu.ie)

Graphs and
Networks

Autumn Semester, 2026/27

Collections

Outline

- Propositions and fundamental logical operators (AND, OR and NOT).
- Evaluating logical expression using truth tables.
- Satisfiability, Tautologies and Contradictions.

Enumeration

Relations & Functions

Thought for the day ...

While walking through a fictional forest, you encounter three identical trolls guarding a bridge. Each troll is either a knight, who always tells the truth, or a knave, who always lies. The trolls will not let you pass until you correctly identify each as either a knight or a knave. Each troll makes a single statement:

If I am a knave, then there are exactly two knights here.



Troll 1 is lying.



Either we are all knaves or at least one of us is a knight..



Which troll are knights? and which are knaves?

Outline

1. Introduction

3

- Propositional logic is concerned with analysing propositions (true or false statements).
- A proposition may be atomic or compound (build up using logical connectives).
- Constructing compound propositions using *And*, *Or* and *Not*.

2. Truth tables

12

- Evaluating an expression for all possible input combinations.

3. Tautologies and Contradictions

20

- Statements that are always true or always false.

Logic

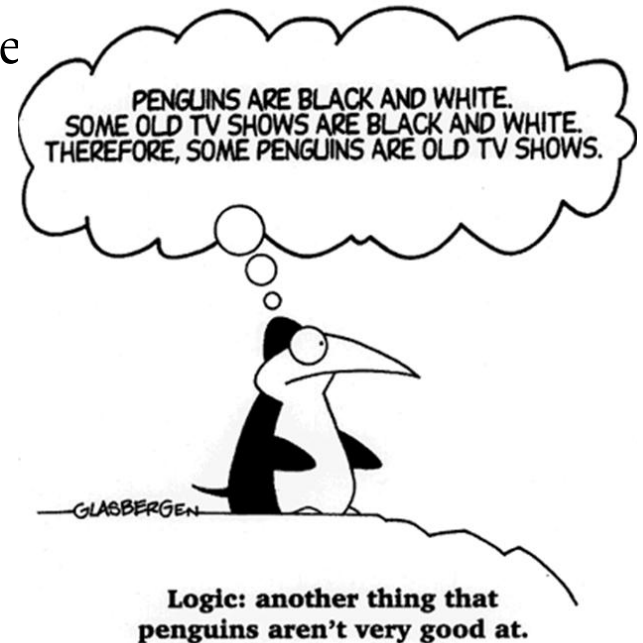
Logic is “science of reasoning”

- Allows us to represent knowledge in precise, unambiguous way.
- Allows us to make valid inferences using a set of consistent rule
- Roots of logic date back to the ancient Greeks, e.g., Aristotle.
- Greeks were interested in valid logical inference rules, such as syllogisms:

“All men are mortal.

Socrates is a man.

Therefore, Socrates is mortal.”



The Partially Examined Life podcast: www.partiallyexaminedlife.com

The Fallacy-a-Day Podcast: <http://fallacyaday.com>

Propositional Logic

I

- The building blocks of propositional logic are propositions

Definition 1 (Proposition)

A **proposition** (**statement**) is a sentence that is either **True** or **False**.

- Examples:

“Java is a programming language.”

True

“Cork is the capital of Ireland.”

False

“ $1 + 2 = 3$ ”

True

“Today is Tuesday.”

depends

“The universe is fine-tuned.”

unknown (at present)

- Examples of sentences that are not propositions/statements:

- *“How are you?”*

— A question cannot be assign a **True/False** value.

- *“Stop sleeping in class!”*

— An order cannot be assign a **True/False** value.

- *“Correct horse battery staple.”*

— Not a sentence.

- *“This sentence is false.”*

— Pathological example.

Propositional Variables, Truth Value

Given a proposition we are interested in knowing its **truth value**.

Definition 2 (Truth Value)

The **truth value** of a proposition identifies whether a proposition is false (written **False** or **F** or 0) or true (written **True** or **T** or 1).

Question

What is truth value of “*Tuesday is the day after Sunday*” ?

F

Notation

- Variables that represent propositions are called propositional variables.
- Denote propositional variables using lower-case letters, such as $p, p_1, p_2, q, r, s, \dots$
- Truth value of a propositional variable is either **T** or **F**.

- | Connective | Symbol | Python |
|-------------------|----------|------------------|
| conjunction (AND) | $\wedge$ | <code>and</code> |
| disjunction (OR) | $\vee$ | <code>or</code> |
| negation (NOT) | $\neg$ | <code>not</code> |

- Today is wet and I am hungry
- atomic atomic
- compound

Exercise

Classify each of the sentences below as an atomic statement, a compound statement, or not a statement at all.

- ① The sum of the first 100 odd positive integers.
- ② Everybody needs somebody sometime.
- ③ Waterford will win the All-Ireland or I'll eat my hat.
- ④ Go to your room!
- ⑤ Every natural number greater than 1 is either prime or composite.
- ⑥ This sentence is false.

Conjunction (AND)

- **Conjunction** of two propositions, p and q , written as $p \wedge q$, is the proposition:
“ p and q ”
- What is the relationship between the truth value of p and of q and the truth value of $p \wedge q$?

$$p \wedge q = \begin{cases} \mathbf{T} & \text{if both } p \text{ is } \mathbf{T} \text{ and } q \text{ is } \mathbf{T} \\ \mathbf{F} & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Example

What is the conjunction and the truth value of $p \wedge q$ for ...

- $p = \text{“It is a autumn semester”}$, $q = \text{“Today is Thursday”}$
- $p = \text{“It is Tuesday”}$, $q = \text{“It is morning”}$

Disjunction (OR)

- **Disjunction** of two propositions, p and q , written as $p \vee q$, is the proposition
“ p or q ”
- What is the relationship between the truth value of p and of q and the truth value of $p \vee q$?

$$p \vee q = \begin{cases} \mathbf{T} & \text{if either } p \text{ is } \mathbf{T} \text{ or } q \text{ is } \mathbf{T}, \text{ or both are } \mathbf{T} \\ \mathbf{F} & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Example

What is the disjunction and the truth value of $p \vee q$ for ...

- $p = \text{“It is a autumn semester”}$, $q = \text{“Today is Thursday”}$
- $p = \text{“It is Friday”}$, $q = \text{“It is morning”}$

Negation (NOT)

- **Negation** of a proposition, p , written, $\neg p$, represents the proposition:

“It is not the case that p .”

- What is the relationship between the truth value of p and $\neg p$?

If p is **T**, then $\neg p$ is **F** and vice versa.

- In simple English, what is $\neg p$ if p stands for ...

p	$\neg p$
“ <i>Today is Tuesday.</i> ”	“ <i>Today is not Tuesday.</i> ”
“ $1 + 1 = 2$ ”	“ $1 + 1 \neq 2$ ”

- Properties of NOT

- $\neg \neg p = p$

Outline

1. Introduction

3

- Propositional logic is concerned with analysing propositions (true or false statements).
- A proposition may be atomic or compound (build up using logical connectives).
- Constructing compound propositions using *And*, *Or* and *Not*.

2. Truth tables

12

- Evaluating an expression for all possible input combinations.

3. Tautologies and Contradictions

20

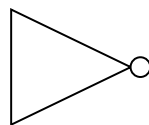
- Statements that are always true or always false.

Propositional Formulas and Truth Tables

- A **propositional formula** is logical expression constructed from atomic and compound propositions and logical connectives.
- A **truth table** for a propositional formula, A , shows the truth value of A for every possible value of its constituent atomic propositions.

Not / Negation

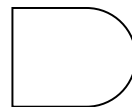
p	$\neg p$
F	T
T	F



NOT

And / Conjunction

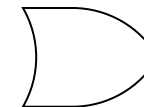
p	q	$p \wedge q$
F	F	F
F	T	F
T	F	F
T	T	T



AND

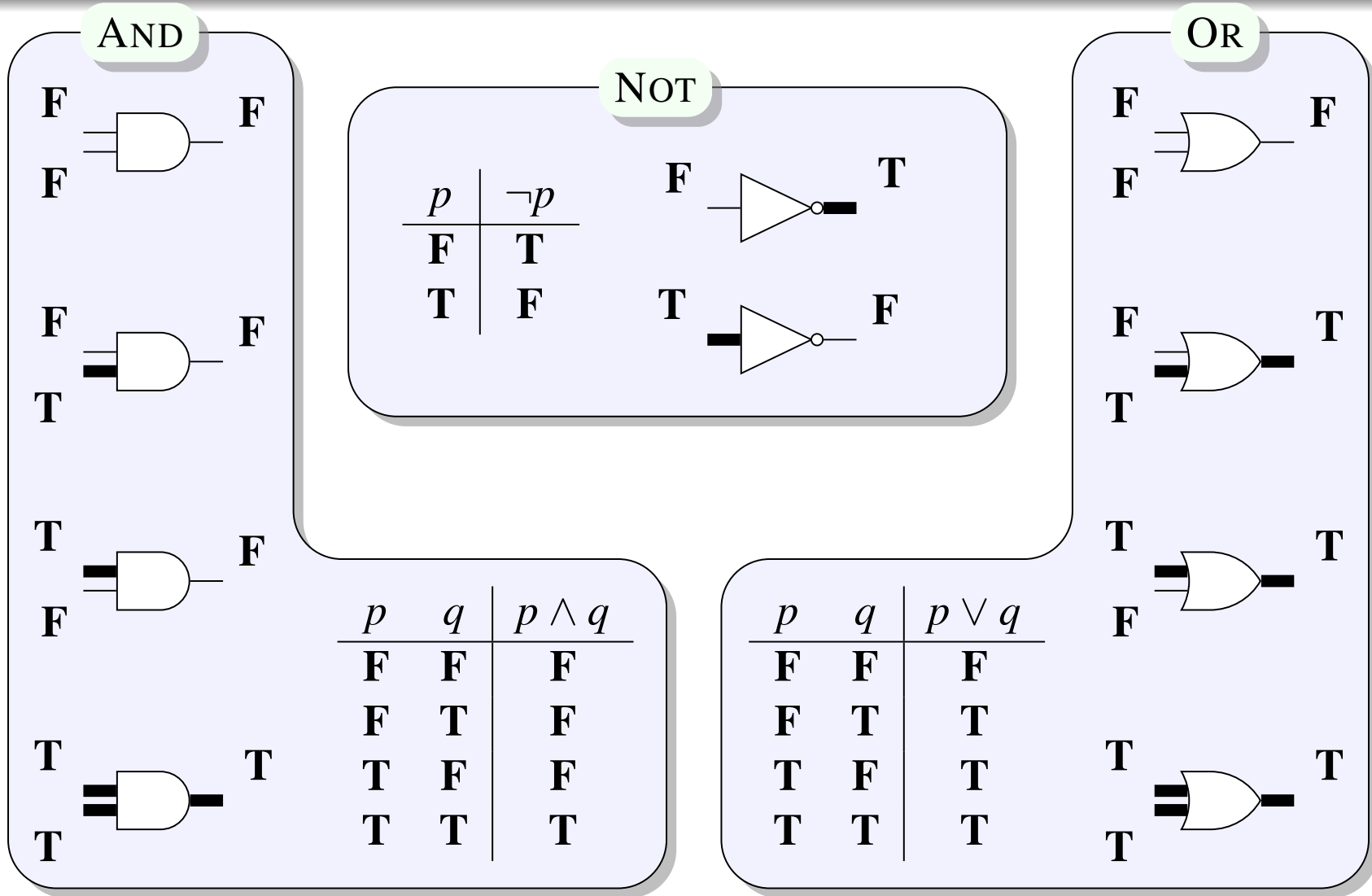
Or / Disjunction

p	q	$p \vee q$
F	F	F
F	T	T
T	F	T
T	T	T



OR

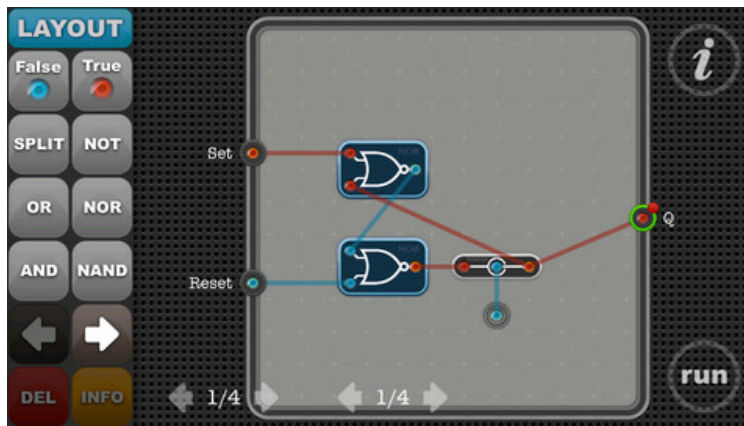
Truth tables and Logic Gates



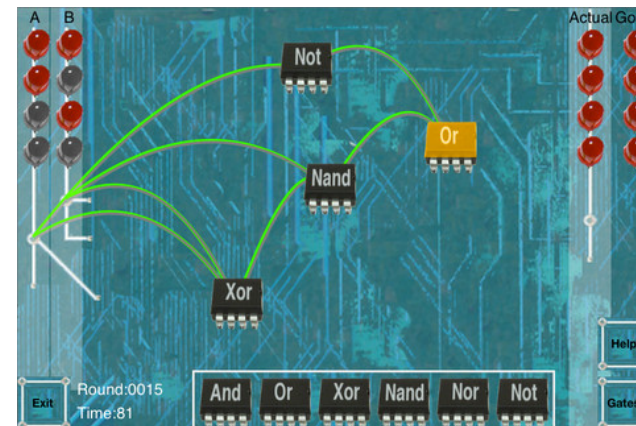
Other Resources

iPad/iPhone Apps (assume similar on Android)

Circuit Coder



Boolean Master



Videos

- <https://class.coursera.org/cs101/lecture/17>
Part of the Computer Science 101 by Nick Parlante on coursera.

Constructing Truth Tables

Useful strategy for constructing truth tables for a formula:

- STEP 1 Identify the constituent atomic propositions of the formula.
- STEP 2 Identify compound propositions in within the formula in increasing order of complexity, including the formula itself.
- STEP 3 Construct a table enumerating all combinations of truth values for atomic propositions.
- STEP 4 Fill in values of compound propositions for each row.

Examples

Construct truth tables for the following formulas:

- 1 $(p \vee q) \wedge \neg p$
- 2 $(p \wedge q) \vee (\neg p \wedge \neg q)$
- 3 $(p \vee q \vee \neg r) \wedge r$

Example 1: $(p \vee q) \wedge \neg p$

- STEP 1** Identify the constituent atomic propositions ... p and q
- STEP 2** Identify compound propositions ...
- STEP 3** Enumerate all combinations of truth values for atomic propositions ...
- STEP 4** Fill in values of compound propositions for each row ...

p	q	$p \vee q$	$\neg p$	$(p \vee q) \wedge \neg p$
F	F	F	T	F
F	T	T	T	T
T	F	T	F	F
T	T	T	F	F

Example 2: $(p \wedge q) \vee (\neg p \wedge \neg q)$

- STEP 1** Identify the constituent atomic propositions ... p and q
- STEP 2** Identify compound propositions ...
- STEP 3** Enumerate all combinations of truth values for atomic propositions ...
- STEP 4** Fill in values of compound propositions for each row ...

p	q	$(p \wedge q)$	$\neg p$	$\neg q$	$(\neg p \wedge \neg q)$	$(p \wedge q) \vee (\neg p \wedge \neg q)$
F	F	F	T	T	T	T
F	T	F	T	F	F	F
T	F	F	F	T	F	F
T	T	T	F	F	F	T

Example 3: $(p \vee q \vee \neg r) \wedge r$

- STEP 1** Identify the constituent atomic propositions ... p , q , and r
- STEP 2** Identify compound propositions ...
- STEP 3** Enumerate all combinations of truth values for atomic propositions ...
- STEP 4** Fill in values of compound propositions for each row ...

p	q	r	$\neg r$	$(p \vee q \vee \neg r)$	$(p \vee q \vee \neg r) \wedge r$
F	F	F	T	T	F
F	F	T	F	F	F
F	T	F	T	T	F
F	T	T	F	T	T
T	F	F	T	T	F
T	F	T	F	T	T
T	T	F	T	T	F
T	T	T	F	T	T

Outline

1. Introduction

3

- Propositional logic is concerned with analysing propositions (true or false statements).
- A proposition may be atomic or compound (build up using logical connectives).
- Constructing compound propositions using *And*, *Or* and *Not*.

2. Truth tables

12

- Evaluating an expression for all possible input combinations.

3. Tautologies and Contradictions

20

- Statements that are always true or always false.

Introduction to Propositional Logic — Summary

1. Introduction

3

- Propositional logic is concerned with analysing propositions (true or false statements).
- A proposition may be atomic or compound (build up using logical connectives).
- Constructing compound propositions using *And*, *Or* and *Not*.

2. Truth tables

12

- Evaluating an expression for all possible input combinations.

3. Tautologies and Contradictions

20

- Statements that are always true or always false.

Satisfiable, Tautologies and Contradictions

Satisfiable

A proposition is **satisfiable** if it is **True** for at least one set of inputs (case).

Tautology

A **tautology** is an expression involving logical variables that is **True** in all cases.

- Examples

- $p \vee \neg p$
- $(p \wedge q) \vee (p \wedge \neg q) \vee \neg p$

“Tomorrow, I will be dead or I will be alive”

Contradiction

A **contradiction** is an expression involving logical variables that is **False** in all cases.

- Examples

- $p \wedge \neg p$

“On Friday, I will win the lottery and not win the lottery.”